CHAPTER 5

The "Ports of India": Ghazna and Bust-Lashkari Bazar

We witness in this chapter the coalescence of the third Shansabani lineage at Ghazna, and the architectural manifestations of this process at the erstwhile Yamini capital and its contiguous areas. Stylistic developments evidenced in the architectural fabrics of the principal palace at Ghazna (Figures 5.1–5.7), and of many of the built remains at Bust (Figures 5.9–5.13) and Lashkari Bazar (Figures 5.14–5.28), serve as plausible evidence of extensive Shansabani-period renovations there, most probably commissioned by Mu'izz al- Din himself. There is very little evidence, however, of new construction. From the surviving remains, we might surmise that, at least among some segments of the Ghazna Shansabani elites, the large-scale interventions at all of these sites were indications of a shift toward greater sedentism – perhaps better described as an emerging tendency toward residence in permanent rather than textile structures. These indices of change appear to have been carried even further upon the Shansabanis' entry into the north Indian *duab*, and will be treated in detail in Volume II.

Juzjani cursorily noted Mu'izz al-Din's summer and winter capitals (*dar al-mulk-i tabistan* and *dar al-mulk-i zamistan*) as Ghazna *and* Khurasan, and eventually Lahore *and* Hind (respectively). Thus, the sultan's residence was not limited to a principal city, but rather also encompassed its vicinity, not unlike the Saljuqs' royal encampments around Isfahan and other major urban centers.[1] Such an arrangement could have accommodated the requirements of both imperial expansion *and* the echoes of a transhumant lifestyle, facilitating campaigns in the respective areas where climate and resources were amenable. It is worth re-emphasizing that the Yamini–Ghaznavids also changed locations according to summer and winter: they had tended to avoid the cold and snowy winters of Ghazna, instead undertaking campaigns to the north Indian plains when the oppressive heat of summer was absent there.[2] It might appear that the Ghazna Shansabanis' movements followed in the seasonal footsteps of their predecessors. But in fact, these two dynastic elites converged upon these *modi operandi* through vastly different historical trajectories – the Shansabanis emerging from nomadism/transhumance within their scions' lifetimes, and the Ghaznavids adapting an inherited Perso-Islamic courtly culture to their specific circumstances (cf. Chapter 1).